

followup

Ginger—original or copied?

Fantatising about Segway's self-balancing scooter, Ginger, that we covered in the January issue? It is not so smooth sailing for Ginger aka 'Segway Human Transporter'. The speed breaker in Ginger's path comes from Japan.



Kazuo Yamafuji, a robotics professor from Tokyo's University of Telecommunications claims that he developed an almost identical machine 15 years ago. He even got a patent for it in 1996. It may not be a major problem for Dean Kamen to sell the

scooter, but he may have problems selling it in Japan. That's missing out on a very lucrative market for Segway.

Yamaguchi claims that the basic principles in his 'parallel bicycle' and Segway are the same. Both use a microprocessor to detect minute shifts in balance. This keeps the scooter upright on two wheels. He also holds a patent for a similar four-wheeled version.

BUGGED PLAYERS

That innocent looking Windows Media Player (WMP) on your PC might be allowing Web sites to keep track of your habits. The bug preys on users of Internet Explorer 6 and older versions of Netscape that use the WMP plug in. Web site operators can actually pull off a default serial number generated by WMP using a client-ID request. This serial number remains the same for every browser session that you have. It can be sent back to the site to track your habits. All this can be done using a simple block of code from the Web site operator's end. Termed 'SuperCookie' by security experts, it can be disabled by turning off javascript or by removing WMP. An updated WMP has also been launched by Microsoft, which allows this feature to be turned off.

AOL-Time Warner eyeing Red Hat

AOL, the media giant, is planning to acquire Red Hat Inc, the distributor of the popular Linux OS. With a mighty 33 million Internet subscriber base, AOL is planning to package its AOL Internet software with Red Hat's operating system to fight against the Redmond Giant.

With the acquisition of Red Hat, AOL plans to make disruptive inroads into the

Microsoft OS business. AOL has been counteracting Microsoft's plans in many ways including enhancing their Netscape browser to fight MS's Internet Explorer. Netscape technology was also implemented in the tabletop Internet terminal from Gateway Inc and Sony's PlayStation 2. Linux has a fairly bad desktop user market due to the high technical skill level

it requires for setup, but it is immensely popular among the 'techie' crowd. The merger plans to strike at the roots of Microsoft's dominance in the desktop OS market. AOL is planning to achieve a reasonable OS market share by providing simpler, easier and cheaper versions of the OS to its consumers bundled with the famous AOL Internet software.

realitybites

"Software makers should be punished for products with bad security"

National Academy of Sciences (NAS) panel suggesting that the US Congress should make it easier to punish companies making insecure software

Microsoft got the hint:

"Our new design approaches the need to dramatically reduce the number of such (security) issues"

Bill Gates in a memo to his employees

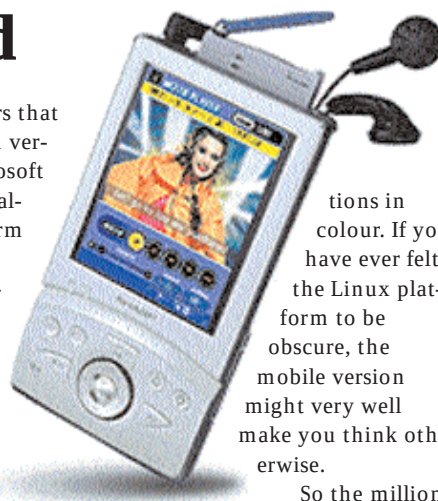
Linux hits the road

Linux and Windows are at it again. The two adversaries have fought many battles in the past with the first frontier being servers, an area where Linux has stayed ahead. The next clash was for supremacy for the desktop. But here Microsoft reigns supreme despite several challenges from Linux over the past several years.

That makes the scoreboard stand at 1-1 (arguably) if you are keeping a watch on that.

With the introduction of

handheld computers that use a stripped down version of Linux, Microsoft now faces a new challenge to that platform in addition to the already strong competition from Palm. If it's as good as it sounds, Pocket PC is going to be sweating bullets. Like its rival, the Linux PDA is capable of running feature-rich applica-



tions in colour. If you have ever felt the Linux platform to be obscure, the mobile version might very well make you think otherwise.

So the million dollar question now is: who will score next?